

AI FOR IMPACT · BOSTON LXP 2026

DAY 1

SESSION 1 · INTRO DAY

From Idea to Impact

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International
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Welcome to AI for Impact

*Over four 3-hour sessions, every team builds an AI solution:
Identify a real problem, design an AI-driven solution, prototype it, craft a business, and pitch it like a founder.*

- **Where you are:** Boston – global hub of AI startups, healthcare innovation, and university research.
- **Who you are:** ESCEN business and ESCENTECH tech students working concurrently on shared project topics.
- **What you leave with:** A credible AI solution, a working prototype, a 10-minute investor pitch, and a final report.
- **How we work:** Short intros, work sessions, mentoring rotations. Each session is 3 hours
- **Between Sessions:** What does not get done in class is homework before the next session.



Same project. Different depth, depending on your discipline.

Business lens · MBA-level expectations

- **Problem depth:** stakeholder mapping, root cause, why-now.
- **Market understanding:** real sources, named competitors, analysis.
- **Monetization:** revenue model, unit economics, pricing logic.
- **Strategic decisions:** trade-offs, sequencing, defensibility.
- **Value narrative:** a CFO would write a check after your pitch.

Tech lens · AI prototyping & experimentation

- **AI logic:** inputs, outputs, which AI primitive does the work, why
- **Tool selection:** APIs, no-code, vibecoding - shipped, not theorized
- **Prototype:** a functional experiment your team can demo live
- **Feasibility:** latency, cost, accuracy, failure modes - named honestly
- **Logic narrative:** a CTO would build on what you shipped

AI for Impact rests on three pillars - all students engage all three

1

Business Strategy

Every student - business and tech
- owns the value narrative.

No "I just did the tech part".

2

AI Capabilities

Every student understands what
AI does in their product and why
it is necessary.

3

Practical Experimentation

Every student participates in
prototyping. Mockups count;
functional prototypes win the
bonus.

The 5-step project arc

One project, same steps for everyone. Each step has a question every team must answer crisply.



Eight themes - each team picks one

Pick a theme where the problem is real, the market is active, and your team has at least one passionate voice.

- **AI for Media & Content Creation:** Tools for creators, agencies, publishers.
- **Retail & Shopping Experience:** Discovery, personalization, conversion, returns.
- **Education & Workforce Development:** Learning, upskilling, hiring, credentialing.
- **Non-Profit & Social Good:** Service delivery, fundraising, transparency.
- **Sustainability & Green Innovation:** Climate, energy, circular economy.
- **Healthcare & Well-being:** Patients, providers, payers, mental health.
- **Startup & Venture Growth:** Tools for founders and operators.
- **AI for Community Engagement & Inclusion:** Civic, language access, accessibility.

Three questions every team must answer

1

Who hurts?

Name a specific user. Not "people" or "businesses" - a role, a context, a frequency of pain.

2

Why hasn't it been solved?

There is a reason. Is it tech? Cost? Distribution? Incentives? Naming it sharpens your edge.

3

Why now?

What changed? New AI capability? New regulation? New behavior? "Now" must be defensible.



The AI justification question - asked every day

Every team revisits this question on every day. By Day 4 you must have a strong, defensible answer.

- **Day 1 first cut:** In one sentence, what would your product look like without AI? Is that version meaningfully worse, or just different?
- **Day 2 sharpened:** Which AI primitive does the work? Generate, classify, extract, retrieve, or act? Why this one?
- **Day 3 stress-tested:** If GPT-5 launches tomorrow and is free, does your product still have a moat?
- **Day 4 pitched:** Can you answer "Why AI?" in one sentence that an investor remembers?

How today flows

Short intros lead into team work and mentoring rotations.

Time	Block	What happens
0:00-0:20	Welcome & framing	Why Boston. Success by Day 4. How we work this week.
0:20-0:50	AI for Impact thesis	Three pillars. Winners and losers. Why all students engage all three.
0:50-1:10	5-step arc + two lenses	Map deliverables onto the week. Business and tech depth expectations.
1:10-1:50	Theme carousel	~5 min per theme: market signal, problem example, open question.
1:50-2:30	Problem-finding workshop	Silent writing, trio sharing, mentor rotations.
2:30-3:00	Team formation + theme lock-in	Mixed teams. One theme. One brief on the wall.

HOMEWORK

Complete the one-page Problem Brief if not finished in class.
Specific user, why-now, why-unsolved, first-cut AI necessity argument.

What "good" looks like vs. "weak"

Weak Day 1 brief

AI for Healthcare. We want to help doctors with documentation using a chatbot. People are busy. This is a big market.

Problem: Vague. No user. No "why now". "Big market" is not evidence. No defensible AI necessity.

Strong Day 1 brief

- **User:** ICU nurses on 12-hour shifts at urban academic hospitals
- **Pain:** 90 min/shift on charting, mostly retyping vitals already in EHR
- **Why now:** voice models accurate enough on medical vocabulary (post-2024)
- **Why unsolved:** EHR vendors lock the API; nurses, not doctors, are the buyer
- **AI necessity:** voice + structured extraction - neither possible without recent AI

END OF DAY 1

Your deliverable: Problem Brief

A one-page brief per team.

Problem statement. Specific user. **Why-now.** Why-unsolved. **First-cut hypothesis on the AI solution shape and AI necessity.**

IF NOT FINISHED IN CLASS - DUE BEFORE NEXT SESSION

Finish the Problem Brief.

If your team has not aligned on one user and one why-now, do that before next session.

T O M O R R O W

Day 2: From problem to a defensible AI solution